them he had left his Adidas bag behind, saying that it contained his shoes rather than a gold watch. Then we rushed back and, to our enormous relief, an elderly lady handed over the bag with a smile.

The road to the final

Our next three matches were against Kenya, Sri Lanka and New Zealand and we won them all convincingly. India were playing fantastic cricket and we had started to believe that we could give Australia a run if we made the final. Here I am a bit embarrassed to reveal a very personal secret relating to the Sri Lanka match. On the eve of the match I had a bad stomach and was feeling dehydrated. This happened because I had not yet fully recovered from the cramp I had suffered while playing Pakistan and as a result had had a lot of isotonic drinks. I also added a teaspoon of salt to the energy drinks, thinking it would help the recovery, and that caused a tummy upset. In fact, the situation was so bad that I had to bat with tissues inside my underwear. I even had to go back to the dressing room during one of the drinks breaks and was feeling extremely uncomfortable in the middle. I somehow scored 97, but batting with stomach cramps wasn't a pleasant experience. I was pushing myself to the limits of endurance and in the end I was glad that the effort paid off.

India were now in the semi-final and we were drawn to play Kenya, who had caused a stir by beating a few of the top-ranked teams. In fact, during the match between Kenya and Sri Lanka, which we watched in the games room in our hotel, a rather odd thing happened. Every time we said something good about a Sri Lankan player, the player got out. It was strange and in no time Kenya had caused a huge upset.

We played our semi-final against Kenya at Durban and managed to win the match comfortably. Sourav and I had a very good partnership and the team managed 270 in our fifty overs before bowling the Kenyans out for 179. We were in the World Cup final, with eight straight wins behind us. The defeat to Australia in the qualifying rounds seemed a lifetime away. Now we were playing them in the final and we were convinced we had the team to stop them from winning back-to-back world titles.

So near and yet so far